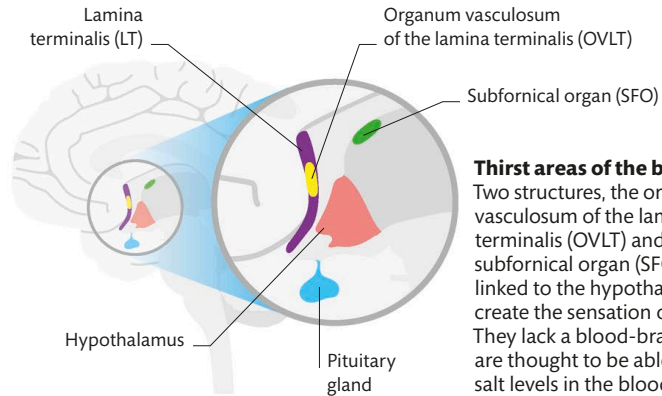




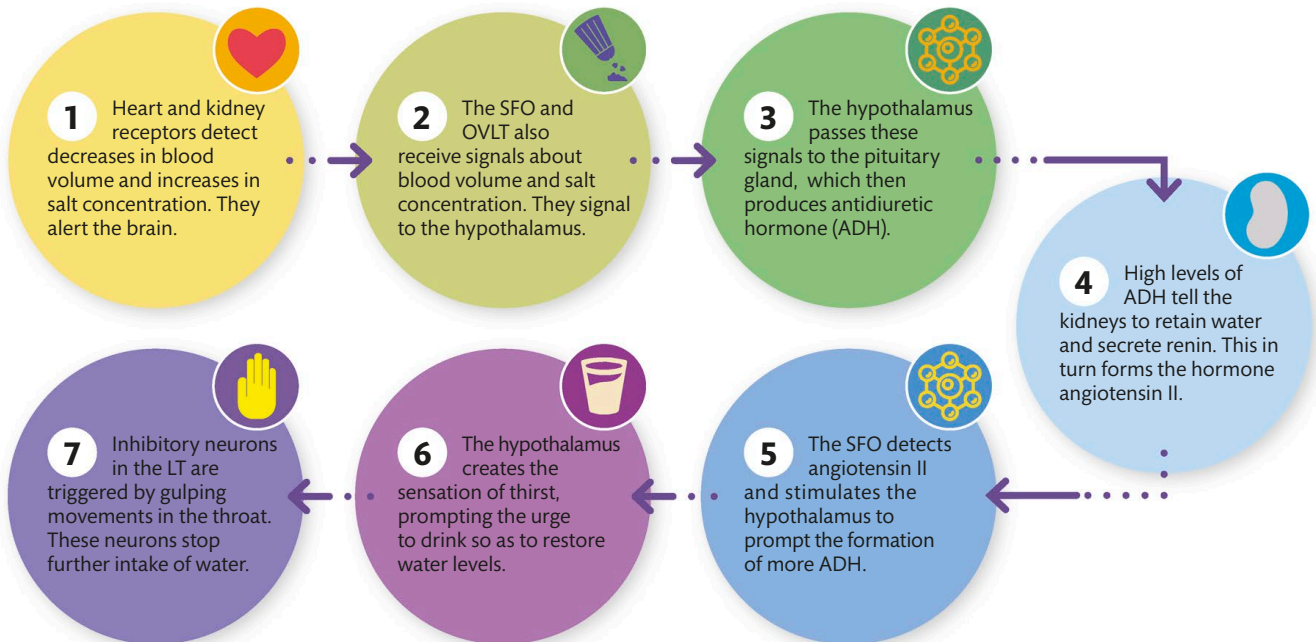
Thirst

When water levels in the body drop, salt levels in the blood increase. Thirst areas in the brain detect rising salt levels and signal to the body to increase water levels by reducing urine output and taking in more fluids. After drinking, it takes around 15 minutes before salt concentration levels in the blood return to normal. It is thought that the gulping action of the throat when swallowing liquids sends signals to stop drinking.



Thirst areas of the brain

Two structures, the organum vasculosum of the lamina terminalis (OVLT) and the subfornical organ (SFO)—both linked to the hypothalamus—help create the sensation of thirst. They lack a blood-brain barrier so are thought to be able to detect salt levels in the blood.



HOW LONG CAN YOU SURVIVE WITHOUT FOOD OR WATER?

Three to four days is the average without water, but you can go up to two months without food in certain circumstances.

ARE YOU DEHYDRATED?

The most obvious symptoms of dehydration are a dry mouth and eyes, and perhaps a slight headache. Another good way to tell is by the color of your urine. It should be pale yellow at full hydration. A darker amber color shows severe dehydration. Adults should take in around 3½–4 pints (2–2.5 liters) of fluids a day.

